

Report finds Gaetz paid girl, 17, for sex

Ethics Committee concludes he violated House rules, federal laws

BY JACQUELINE ALEMANY, JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND MARIANNA SOTOMAYOR

Former congressman Matt Gaetz (R-Florida) regularly paid for sex, possessed illegal drugs and paid a 17-year-old girl for sex in 2017, according to a 42-page report released by the House Ethics Committee on Monday on President-elect Donald Trump's former pick for attorney general.

The report cited "substantial evidence" that from 2017 to 2020, Gaetz "regularly paid women for engaging in sexual activity with him," and from 2017 to 2019, possessed illegal drugs, including cocaine and ecstasy, on "multiple different occasions." The Ethics Committee also investigated a 2018 trip Gaetz made to the Bahamas where the panel found he accepted transportation and lodging in violation of the House rules and laws on gifts.

The bipartisan committee concluded in the document that Gaetz "violated House Rules, state and federal laws, and other standards of conduct prohibiting prostitution, statutory rape, illicit drug use, acceptance of impermissible gifts, the provision of special favors and privileges, and obstruction of Congress."

Gaetz has denied all the allegations against him.

Until a few weeks ago, Gaetz was one of the leading voices of Republicans and the MAGA movement. SEE GAETZ ON A5

Zelensky shifts tone on talks, territory

Trump's return, setbacks in war appear to push Ukrainian leader to table

BY ISABELLE KHURSHUDYAN AND ELLEN FRANCIS

KYIV — As Ukrainian forces struggle to hold off Russia's army on the battlefield and President-elect Donald Trump looks to broker a peace deal, President Volodymyr Zelensky has in recent weeks signaled a greater willingness for negotiations to end the war — a major shift for the Ukrainian leader, who had long vowed to fight for every last inch of his country's land.

Zelensky's messaging has been careful; he has not explicitly said Kyiv would agree to concessions — territorial or otherwise — even as Russia occupies more than 20 percent of Ukraine and would probably retain control of that land after any ceasefire. But after previously stating that negotiations could begin only once Moscow withdrew all its troops, Zelensky is now emphasizing the need for long-term security rather than the immediate return of territory.

Zelensky's change in rhetoric — SEE ZELENSKY ON A9

Corruption claims: Watchdog calls for probe of faulty mortar shells. A9

Syrian Christians mark a festive season



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

A couple walks through holiday decorations at the historic Bab Sharqi, one of the seven ancient city gates in the old town of Damascus, Syria, on Monday. The country is heading into an uncertain future as the year ends with upheaval following the ouster of longtime President Bashar al-Assad.

Living in dire fear, Syrians communicated in code

BY RUBY MELLEN AND MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA

For decades, Syrians passed down a warning from one generation to the next: "The walls have ears." In cafes, taxis and markets — even in their own living rooms — most could not speak freely, fearing they might be overheard by Bashar al-Assad's Mukhabarat, or secret police. To maintain its grip, the Assad regime planted fear, its roots spreading into every aspect of civilian life. Street cleaners, garbage collectors, balloon sellers, colleagues — anyone could be an informant.

"Fear in the country reached a level that you felt like you can't even trust your family," said Ayman Rifai, a 26-year-old resident of Damascus.

'We used to ... point toward the ceiling' to mean the government

In this environment of surveillance, Syrians improvised. They developed a code allowing them to discuss everything from everyday commerce to fears for their families, even veiled criticisms of the regime. The phrases and signals were used among trusted family and friends.

"You had to have coded language among Syrians because there was no real freedom of expression," said Alia Malek, the author of "The Home That Was Our Country: A Memoir of Syria."

"You never knew who was listening, no matter where you were. Even in their absence, they were present," Malek said of the regime.

"You can't talk at all about the regime," said Maysoun, 49, who spoke on the condition she be identified only by her first name because she fears reprisals from Assad supporters. "If we want to nag about something, we used to mime it with our finger and point toward the ceiling meaning the government."

If Syrians were suspicious of someone nearby, they would say, "This person has nice handwriting," which means, "This person is an informant."

Maysoun has lived not only in Damascus but also in Lebanon and France. She never felt safe

from the regime, even outside the country. Any time she was in a large group of Syrians, she wondered whether someone in the group had "nice handwriting," she recalled.

She and her family fled Damascus in 2012 for Beirut. There, for the first time, her 7-year-old daughter began to hear the stories of Assad's atrocities that her parents had tried so hard to shield her from.

A year later, they decided to return home, clinging to the hope that the worst had passed. But rumors circulated that guards at checkpoints were asking children who their favorite political leader

SEE SYRIA ON A8

Uncertain future: Trump will face immediate questions in Syria. A7

Dozens on death row are spared

BIDEN COMMUTES 37 FEDERAL SENTENCES

Recent push had urged action on capital cases

BY MARK BERMAN AND MATT VISER

President Joe Biden on Monday said he was commuting the sentences of 37 of the 40 prisoners on federal death row to life without parole, taking the unprecedented step ahead of the inauguration of President-elect Donald Trump, whose incoming administration is widely expected to restart executions.

Opponents of capital punishment had been urging Biden to use his final weeks in office to empty federal death row before Trump reclaims the White House. Trump is a longtime supporter of the death penalty, and his first administration carried out 13 federal executions.

Biden's sweeping decision marks the first presidential commutation of a death sentence since President Barack Obama took two prisoners off death row in 2017. Biden kept death sentences in place for three federal prisoners, who he said were involved in cases of "terrorism and hate-motivated mass murder."

Those he did not spare are: Dylann Roof, the white supremacist convicted of killing nine Black parishioners at a South Carolina church in 2015; Robert Bowers, who carried out the country's deadliest antisemitic attack when he killed 11 people at the Tree of Life synagogue in Pittsburgh in 2018; and Dzhokhar Tsarnaev, the Boston Marathon bomber.

The federal death penalty population accounts for a relatively small share of the people sentenced to death throughout the country. A Washington Post examination this year found that there are more than 2,100 prisoners with death sentences nationwide. SEE BIDEN ON A4

On the list: Who was spared, who wasn't, and what's next. A4

A nurse's confidants recall signs of danger

Mamta Kafle Bhatt's loved ones detail the abuse they say she suffered before her disappearance

BY EMMA UBER

At first, Mamta Kafle Bhatt's co-worker believed her when she said the bruises on her face came from a fall.

But when she showed up for her nursing shift in February crying and hurt again, Sunita Basnet texted her the number for a domestic violence hotline.

"Thank you so much di," Kafle Bhatt replied, using the shortened version of didi — big sister in Nepali.

"I would like to try couple counseling to give him one chance for being a better person," she continued, in an exchange reviewed by The Washington Post that Basnet said referred to Kafle Bhatt's husband, Naresh Bhatt. "I realized I love him so much. I don't want

to put him in trouble."

Not long after, Kafle Bhatt transferred hospitals and stopped responding to Basnet's messages, Basnet said. Then, nearly four months ago, the 28-year-old pediatric nurse stopped calling her family in Nepal. She missed her final U.S. citizenship appointment and her daughter's first birthday.

A grand jury indicted Naresh Bhatt, 37, on a murder charge this month. Prosecutors allege he dismembered her body and disposed of it in pieces, using gloved hands to toss bags into a trash compactor late at night. DNA tests linked her to blood found on a handheld power saw. His lawyer, Shalev Ben-Avraham, declined to comment on the case or allegations of mistreatment in

SEE NURSE ON A16



OLIVIA DIAZ/AP

Flowers and photos sit near Mamta Kafle Bhatt's home in Manassas Park, Virginia, on Sept. 4. This month, a grand jury indicted her husband on a murder charge in her disappearance.

IN THE NEWS

A shift on Israel Joe Biden's presidency has widened a deepening rift among Democrats over support for the nation. A3

Ex-officer convicted Former D.C. police lieutenant Shane Lamond was found guilty of leaking information to the Proud Boys' leader and lying to investigators. B1

THE NATION State Democratic leaders want to make changes to how the party spends money. A2
Experts say a survey has worsened racial disparities in placing people into housing. A6

THE WORLD France's new leadership formed with some new top ministers while maintaining a center-right tilt, replacing a government that was the shortest-serving in the modern republic. A8

THE ECONOMY Exposing kids to music doesn't have to mean more screen time. Some parents are pulling out their cassette and CD players. A10
Honda and Nissan entered into talks about a merger that would create the world's third-largest automaker. A11

THE REGION Maryland's Air National Guard is poised to assume control of D.C.'s 121st Fighter Squadron as part of a deal over the RFK Stadium site. B1
A 36-year-old construction worker died when a rowhouse in Northwest collapsed, leaving his wife to mourn. B1

STYLE **Timothée Chalamet** is excellent as Bob Dylan in "A Complete Unknown," but Edward Norton steals the show as Pete Seeger. C1

HEALTH & SCIENCE **More people** are surviving with metastatic cancer, giving hope to others fighting the disease. E1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A10
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A12
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A7

CONTENT © 2024
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54075

0 170628 211001 3